In response to the SIT's release of Dixon's photo in the press and a subsequent release of a photo of Sivarasan, too, in which he was not seen wearing his false eye, on 24 July, an informer from Coimbatore claimed to have seen 'Dixon' often making calls from a particular telephone booth opposite the Punjab National Bank in Jawahar Nagar. Kaarthikeyan immediately moved the tracking team to Coimbatore.

Around the same time in Coimbatore, local police detained two men for violating traffic rules and tripling on a bike in the Gounderpalayam area. All three were made to sit in 'murga' (sitting in a squat, with heads hanging down and hands holding the ears through the back of their legs) in one corner of a police post. The idea was to release them after a couple of hours, the usual drill for such offences. The trio kept seeking forgiveness in their repeated pleas for release. The SP of the area was on his daily round. He had casually dropped in at the police post for a glass of water. The trio, speaking Tamil with a strong Sinhala accent, did not go unnoticed. He took extra interest in them and found, to his horror, that they were members of the LTTE. They were immediately taken to the district police headquarters for interrogation.

One was named 'Vicky' and turned out to be an insider working closely with the Tigers' political group leader Trichy Santhan. Another was 'Raghu'. The third, 'Vijay', was a real estate broker who was taking them to show a new place available for rent.

Vicky, or Vigneshwaran, was a Sri Lankan national. The cloth store his father owned had been destroyed in an air raid by the Sri Lankan air force in 1985. He started ferrying contraband goods between Jaffna and Madras for a living. Two years later, his house was destroyed in a bomb blast. He was sent to a refugee camp in Batticaloa, where he met people who believed only Prabhakaran could get them 'freedom'. Finding no other means of livelihood in violence-stricken Jaffna, Vicky visited Madras again, along with a few wounded LTTE cadres seeking treatment in Tamil Nadu. Vicky's grooming in the rebel cause began. He started working as an assistant to LTTE cadres and gained their confidence. A trusted lieutenant of Pottu Amman, Trichy Santhan was overall in charge of looking after the